

Pygmalion Effect

What is it?

People perform better or worse based on the expectations others place on them.

History

First documented in **1968** through a study by Rosenthal and Jacobson, showing students performed better simply because teachers believed they would.

The Psychology Behind It

Human behavior is influenced by belief and expectation.

When someone is told they are capable, their motivation rises, which improves effort and performance.

Negative expectations do the opposite — lowering confidence, effort, and outcomes.

Why It Matters

- Shapes user confidence
- Influences decisions and flow completion
- Increases motivation and momentum
- Can either uplift or damage the user experience

How to Apply It

- Use positive reinforcement microcopy
- Celebrate small wins with badges + progress
- Reframe failures as learning moments
- Encourage users during friction or tough steps

Theory in Action

Duolingo uses supportive language like “You’re learning fast!” and reframes mistakes as “still learning” to keep motivation high.

Nike’s “Just Do It” pushes belief and expectation that anyone can achieve greatness.

Final Thought

The stories users hear about themselves shape what they do next. Raise expectations in the interface — and users rise with it.

